A few sparks of the classical period would remain alive in the city of Vijaynagar in the far South and in the even more faraway kingdoms of South East Asia. However, India was embarking on a new cycle of urbanization that derived many of its elements from Central Asia and Persia. This book is not meant as a comprehensive history of empires, individuals and events. I will, therefore, deal with this cycle of urbanization largely through the evolution of its most prominent city—Delhi.

THE MANY CITIES OF DELHI

The area in and around Delhi has been inhabited by humans from the Stone Age—stone implements have been found scattered in the ridges of the Aravalli range. The Rig Vedic people would also have been familiar with the region since it falls in the eastern corner of the Sapta-Sindhu landscape. There are even scattered remains of small settlements from the late Harappan age. Perhaps, this was one of the places where the Harappans settled as they abandoned the drying Saraswati and shifted to the Gangetic plains.

Since then, cities have been built, abandoned, pillaged and rebuilt many times on this site. Depending on how you count, between eight and sixteen Delhis have been built through history. Thus, the terms ‘Old Delhi’ and ‘New Delhi’ have meant different things at different points in time. So when William Sleeman visited the city in 1836, he referred to Shahjehanabad, what we now call Old Delhi, as New Delhi [15] . To him, Old Delhi referred to the ruins that were scattered from Mehrauli to Purana Qila—the area that is now occupied by what we call New Delhi. Nevertheless, the current cycle of expansion is remarkable even by standards of the city’s long history. After Delhi was sacked by the British in 1858, its urban population fell to a mere 154,417 as per the 1868 census. [16] Today, the urban system of Delhi, the National Capital Region, is home to almost twenty million people and it continues to grow and evolve rapidly.

As we have already discussed in Chapter 3, many of the events of the Mahabharata relate to the area around Delhi. Indraprastha, the capital of the